

The body's drain

As blood circulates through tissues it leaves behind fluid. The fluid is known as lymph when it drains from the tissue into the lymphatic system. This one-way system of vessels returns lymph to the circulatory system. Along the way, lymph is also filtered to remove germs.

Lymphatic system

Lymph vessels (shown in purple) extend to all parts of the body. Tiny lymph capillaries drain fluid from tissues and then merge to form larger lymph vessels. Two main tubes, or ducts, in the chest empty into the bloodstream. The system also contains swellings called lymph nodes and several organs, such as the tonsils and spleen. These contain immune system cells that kill germs.

Spleen, the largest lymphoid organ, contains immune system cells that destroy germs

Lymph tissue in the small intestine kills germs in food

